

A Space to Belong: The Symposium for Women and Non-Binary Bassists

By Hanxiao Deng

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For this issue's Teaching Tips column, I have invited Hanxiao Deng to reflect on her experience developing the female and non-binary double bass symposium at the Curtis Institute of Music. Teaching the bass is more than just how we shape our left hands and how we draw the bow. Representation is very important in our field, which has been historically male-dominated, and Hanxiao's work is a wonderful example of action leading us to a more equitable future. Gaelen McCormick, column editor.

In the 100-year history of the Curtis Institute of Music, I believe I am the first Asian woman double bassist, and likely only the twelfth woman bassist ever admitted. I've experienced firsthand both the privilege of elite training and the isolation of underrepresentation. In most professional orchestras and conservatories, women and non-binary bassists remain a clear minority. During my studies, I was often the only woman in the room.

The idea for the Symposium was first developed during *The Community Artist Program*, a course taught by Mary Javian at Curtis. In that class, we were encouraged to think beyond traditional career paths and explore how musicians can serve communities in meaningful ways. Through a design-thinking process, Mary guided me in identifying a central question that had long stayed with me: *What would it look like to build a space where women and non-binary bassists could gather, support one another, and thrive?* With her mentorship and structural guidance, that question became the foundation of what would become the Symposium.

What began as a personal wish became a community vision – and eventually, a movement.

Now in its second year, the Symposium for Women and Non-Binary Bassists is a growing initiative grounded in equity, access, mentorship, and representation. This article reflects on its origins, growth, and the collective voice of the community behind it.

The First Step: 2024 Inaugural Symposium

Held from April 19–21, 2024 at the Curtis Institute of Music, the inaugural symposium brought together 20 women bassists ranging in age from 12 to 43, traveling from across the U.S., China, Canada, and Australia. For many, it was their first time seeing a room full of bassists who looked like them.

Our inaugural faculty included:

- Mary Javian, Principal Bassist, American Composers Orchestra; Chair of Career Studies at Curtis, and Symposium mentor—her guidance was invaluable throughout the planning and execution.
- Nina DeCesare, Baltimore Symphony; Faculty, Peabody Conservatory
- Gaelen McCormick, Eastman Community Music School; President, International Society of Bassists
- Lauren Pierce, Soloist
- Dr. Patricia Weitzel, Faculty, Penn State University

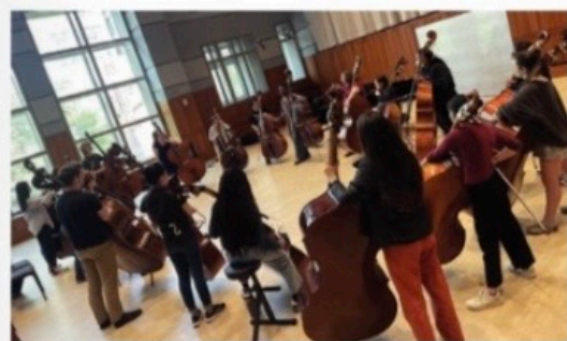
I wanted to create a space where community could form naturally – where students could connect with one another and with faculty, outside of competition or hierarchy. With that in mind, we created a schedule that balanced intensive learning with informal shared meals, conversations, and performances.

Over the weekend, each participant received a private lesson, played in master classes, attended a “Careers in Music” workshop led by Mary Javian, and explored “Performance Mindset” with Gaelen McCormick. They also participated in an “Instrument Setup and Maintenance” workshop, generously led by luthier Anne Marie Runco of Robertson & Sons Violin Shop, where they learned essential techniques for maintaining their instrument's condition and longevity. A culminating recital featured both faculty and participants.

Though the logistics – fundraising, scheduling, and overall coordination – were challenging, I had strong mentorship from Mary Javian and institutional support from Curtis. Balancing faculty availability, securing early sponsorship, promoting the event without a pre-existing network, and managing lesson spaces and meals all required more time and problem-solving than I had anticipated.



2025 Symposium group photo featuring participants and faculty following the opening recital.



Symposium faculty Kebra-Seyoun Charles leading the composition workshop at the 2025 Symposium.

Participant Voices

Each year, the most powerful testament comes from the voices of those who attend. Here are just a few reflections from the 2024 and 2025 participants:

"This weekend changed my relationship to the bass and to myself."

"It was inspiring to be surrounded by people who looked like me – and taught like me."

"The environment was laid back, positive, and non-competitive."

"I finally felt like I belonged."

"This symposium was a huge success! I appreciate bassists of all skill levels being welcome – it truly represents the community."

"Thank you, Hanxiao, for creating this space. Looking forward to next year!"

Just as feedback from 2024 directly informed 2025's development, we are actively incorporating 2025 feedback into future planning. Participants emphasized the value of professional feedback, diverse faculty, and clear communication. They also asked for deeper conversations around representation – an area we hope to expand in future sessions.

What Comes Next

Our hope is to grow the Symposium into an annual tradition. Our long-term vision is to:

- Offer scholarships to support wider access
- Create a digital mentorship and community platform
- Build a sustainable network of visible, empowered bassists in all areas of music

We are currently seeking institutional partners, sponsors, and faculty who share our vision. We also invite performers and educators to share this opportunity with students and colleagues. If you are interested in partnering, mentoring, or supporting this work, we would love to hear from you.

This Symposium began as an act of hope – but through the collective energy of its community, it has become a movement. The low notes we play may often be overlooked, but our voices, when united, can resonate far beyond any stage.

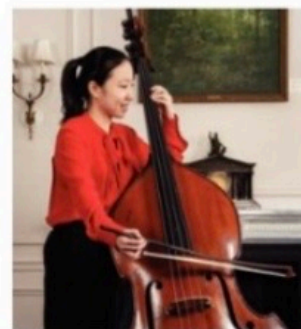
Acknowledgments

The Symposium for Women and Non-Binary Bassists has been made possible by the generous support of our sponsors: Artemis Bass Initiative, Curtis Institute of Music, the International Society of Bassists (ISB), Nick Lloyd Basses, Pinastro Strings, and Robertson & Sons Violin Shop. We thank them for believing in this vision from the very beginning.

Special thanks to Gaelen McCormick, whose support in connecting us with the ISB helped amplify the Symposium's reach and impact.

Hanxiao Deng is a double bassist and recent graduate of the Curtis Institute of Music. She is the founder and director of the Symposium for Women and Non-Binary Bassists, an initiative dedicated to fostering community, representation, and mentorship in the double bass field. As a performer, she has appeared with ensembles including the Chamber Orchestra of Philadelphia, Philadelphia Ballet, Baltimore Symphony Orchestra, Symphony in C, and the National Repertory Orchestra.

In addition to performing, Hanxiao teaches both double bass and piano, and served as a keyboard studies tutor at Curtis. She studied at the Curtis Institute of Music, the Manhattan School of Music, and the Music Middle School affiliated with the Shanghai Conservatory of Music. Her principal teachers include Harold Robinson, Edgar Meyer, Nathaniel West, Jeremy McCoy, and Hui Chao.



Hanxiao Deng (photo by Nichole Howard)





Symposium faculty Gaelen McCormick guiding a "Performance Mindset" workshop at the 2024 Symposium. (All photos were taken by members of the Symposium documentation team. 2024: Tobias Vigneau, Christian Luevano, Dimitrios Mattas, William McGregor)



Symposium mentor and faculty Mary Javian leading a master class during the 2024 Symposium.

Growing the Vision: 2025 Second Annual Symposium

The 2025 symposium, held May 22–25, expanded on everything we had learned from the inaugural event. Our faculty included returning mentors and new voices:

- Mary Javian
- Nina DeCesare
- Heather Miller Lardin, Principal Bass, Handel and Haydn Society
- Kebra-Seyoun Charles, Soloist and Composer
- Brittany Conrad, Section Bass, Milwaukee Symphony Orchestra

We again welcomed 20 bassists, all women and non-binary participants, ages 12 to 44. Feedback from the 2024 cohort directly inspired this year's program enhancements: participants had asked for more opportunities in orchestral training and a space to explore identity in music. To support this, we encouraged open dialogue throughout the weekend and dedicated time for group reflection following master classes and workshops.

We introduced a new Orchestral Training Program and Competition, in partnership with the Artemis Bass

Initiative, offering three prizes:

- First prize: The opportunity to substitute in the Minnesota Orchestra
- Second prize: \$500
- Third prize: \$250

We also launched a Composition Workshop led by Kebra-Seyoun Charles, and expanded to two faculty recitals. All the previous core offerings – private lessons, master classes, campus tours, and community meals – remained intact. We were able to offer registration at a low, all-inclusive cost of \$350. Both years, participants were also eligible to win a full set of Pirastro bass strings through a raffle generously sponsored by Pirastro Strings.



Symposium founder and director Hanxiao Deng with symposium mentor Mary Javian at the 2025 welcome table. (2025 Symposium Photos by Jackson Howard, Gabriel Nishikawa-Madden, Alexander Heather, Maxence Dauriat-Rancirel)



2025 Symposium faculty (left to right): Hanxiao Deng, Mary Javian, Kebra-Seyoun Charles, Brittany Conrad, Nina DeCesare, and Heather Miller Lardin.

We are grateful for our photographers' generous contributions in capturing these moments. While we are unable to attribute each individual photo precisely, every effort has been made to acknowledge all contributing photographers. All participants pictured have given permission for their images to be used in this article.